A Telling of the Turning

For the person who will run it

This is a reading for the person who will run the game. The world book is the reference, the place you go when you need a rule, a share, or a street. This book is the telling. Read it once, in order, and the lands should sit in your head as places that argue with each other. Nothing here is a new fact. The present year, counted from the first successful cutting of the Awakening Tree, is Cut-year 387.

How a person is made

A person in this world is two things at once. The body they are born with is a Kind. Human, elf, the fox-born Kitsune, the sea-born Selkie, the ridge-born Tengu, the isle-born Yumboe, and the other ancestries of Daggerheart are all Kinds. Nobody in a market blinks at wings or a fox-tail. Kind is birth. It is not a country. The fox-born are dense in the dry east and on the high snow because that is the ground, not because a crown of foxes rules it.

What a person becomes is a Condition. About three people in four carry one. The old tales still know the shapes: vampire, werewolf, the walking dead, demon, siren, gorgon, djinn, the wild's people, the phoenix. In this world those are neighbours with jobs. A Condition is given, or it arrives later. It is not a species you are born into, and it stacks on whatever Kind you already are. A Selkie can be Returned. A human can be Long-Lived. A fox-born child can be hugged and stay as they are.

Most Conditions are Given at the Leaf-Fall. In a child's tenth year, at the High Solstice, in the month called Eolthael, the town gathers at its Turning Tree. A leaf falls. The colour names the Condition, and the child is Given. If the leaves close around the child and no colour falls, the child is Kept. A hug is common. About two children in five are hugged at the ceremony, and about a quarter of all people stay Kept for life. A family that teaches "a hug is rare" is teaching a rank, not the count.

Some Conditions cannot be handed to a ten-year-old. You cannot die at ten in the way the Returned die, and a child cannot swear the contract that makes a person Bound. Those arrive later, when a person crosses a threshold: a death, an oath, a drowning, a time spent as stone, a time lost in the wild. That arrival is called Struck. There is no leaf and no ceremony. Onlookers call it a miracle, or bad luck, or a little uncanny. About sixty percent of people are Given at a Tree. About fifteen percent are Struck later. About twenty-five percent stay Kept.

Every Condition has a Tithe, an upkeep the person has to meet or the danger in the Condition starts to show. A Long-Lived person has to keep learning, or the memory fades. One of the Taken-In has to touch living plants, or they wilt. A Far-Voiced person has to let strong feeling out aloud, or it breaks into everyone in earshot. Towns are built around these needs the way other towns are built around wells. The scary edge is real and small. A Tithe must never take the person's will. They still choose what they do.

The Tree that does the giving is a graft. There is one Awakening Tree, Thaeloren, in the old grove on Maiethorn. People call it the First Hand, and they call the grove the Motherwood. Every town Tree is a living cutting of that tree, carried in earth and planted so a child can stand under it at home. People call a planted Tree a Hand, and they call the years when a town Tree is the ordinary way to Turn the Years of Hands. Where the Trees are old and healthy, more children are Given. Where the Trees are few, young, or sick, more children are hugged or miss the week entirely, and more people are Struck later, alone.

Five faiths answer the same fact, that most people become something they were not born as. The Motherfaith says a becoming is a gift a mother chose. The Watching, in Maiethorn's oldest districts, says it is a seeing, and that the mother-name came later. The Fair Hand, on Strandoren's docks, says it is a bargain with terms. The Old Ways, on Heskoren's doors and groves, say it is the land making its own. The Open Table, on Kumbaan, says a becoming is a mainland hunger the isle never had. A devout person and a skeptic can stand at the same Leaf-Fall, because what makes you of a faith here is mostly what you do: you bring the child, you tend the upkeep, you keep the festival. What you privately believe is argued, and it is not usually policed.

If you remember one household, remember this one. A Selkie wife, a husband who Returned from a drowning, a Kept grandmother, and three children who have not stood at a Tree yet. That house is ordinary. Mixed families are not a category anyone remarks on, because almost every family is mixed. The ache, when it comes, is time. A Long-Lived person stops aging and outlives the spouse and the children. People say the cost is measured in funerals, and they mean the dinner table.

The neighbours you will meet

You will know a town by which of these people it cannot do without, and which of them it keeps at the edge.

A Long-Lived person stops aging and does not forget what they have witnessed. The old tales called them vampires. They are rare, about two or three in a hundred, and they are revered and held a little apart. They keep archives, judge disputes, and witness records, because a memory that does not die is what a court and a bank are built on. Their upkeep is learning. Starve them of anything new, in a prison or a dull siege, and they fade. They can read a memory in a single drop of blood. By an old courtesy they will not cross a threshold until they are asked. They can have children. Most of those children age and die. The funerals are the deeper cost. Every Long-Lived person is asked once to join the Pourers. Most say no, and a no is not punished.

A Two-Bodied person carries a second body, a real animal, between a housecat and a large wolf, bear, or horse. The old tales called them werewolves. They are the most common Condition, about eighteen in a hundred, and they do the hauling, herding, rescue, and scouting. The animal has its own name and its own mood. Townsfolk say "that's Bramble, her otter." The person still chooses every action. In the animal shape there are no hands and no human speech. A hawk flies. A person does not. If a full day passes without time in that body, the next roll with Fear shifts them whether they meant it, and they mark a Stress. The timing belongs to the upkeep. The actions stay theirs. The animal runs in families. Children of a Two-Bodied parent usually turn the same animal.

A Returned person died with something unfinished, and that purpose keeps them walking. The old tales called them the walking dead. They are calm, and the living can tell when the purpose is being neglected, because the touch runs cold. Society sends them where the work kills the living: plague wards, mine collapses, the tending of the dead. Their returns are counted. Each time they refuse to stay down, a Hope slot is crossed out. When the purpose is finally done, they may lie down, live on with no Condition, or name a new purpose and keep walking. That choice is theirs, with you.

A Bound person chose it. In some extremity they swore a contract and received a power in exchange for standing terms. The old tales called them demons. The horror is the contract, and

the other party, who watches the ledger. Society fears them and uses them. A sworn word that cannot be shrugged off is how a treaty is made to hold, and many of them can hear a lie. Break a term and the granted power starts to cost, and a whisper begins on a Fear roll. The whisper suggests. It does not command. At signing they also named a piece of themselves, the Pledge, to be collected when a term-limited contract ends. What walks away is Unbound, free of the contract and missing that piece. People call them the Hollow. The hole is a grief and, narrowly, an immunity: effects that would have worked through the missing thing do not. Their upkeep is being known. Rest with someone who knows their name, or the quiet tokens stay empty, and the next offer of power sounds more reasonable than it should. A Bound person who signs contract after contract until the other party effectively holds them is called the Given-Over, and among the contract-guilds the Forfeit. That is not a character the table keeps playing.

A Far-Voiced person's voice carries as far, and as truly, as they mean it to. The old tales called them sirens. The danger lands on them. Feeling has to be let out aloud, in a song, a cry, a laugh, or it leaks, and at the worst it breaks into everyone in earshot as a Cry. That is why the signal network, the courts, and the concert halls run on them. A Given Far-Voiced was trained from childhood. A Struck Far-Voiced survived a drowning and came up untrained. Same voice. Very different person.

One of the Stilled can hold a wound, a poison, or a struggling patient still with a look. The old tales called them gorgons. The stillness has to come from somewhere. Each use of the Gaze adds a little Grey, and a long rest with no hard physical work adds more. They drill, spar, and stay busy so the Grey does not settle into their own limb. They are feared, licensed, and wanted on a riot line and in a surgery. A Given Stilled trained young. A Struck Stilled survived being turned to stone and came back with the stillness already in them.

One of the Answered was answered by an element at the Tree: Ember, Tide, Root, or Gale. The old tales called them djinn. The element obeys their hands. Glass without a full furnace, a hull without steam, stone without a chisel. If they go too long without spending themselves on that work, the element starts to speak on its own, as heat, flood, stiffness, or a gust. Asking the element a question does not pay the upkeep. Using it does. Workshops exist so they have somewhere for the element to go that is not a crowded room.

One of the Taken-In was taken partway into the wild and given back: bark at the knuckles, moss in the hair, green things that lean toward them. The old tales called them leshy, the trickster who led travelers in circles. Here they are why thin soil yields, why a herd gets through a bad winter, and why a person can walk a forest without losing north. They have to touch living plants or they wilt, and at the worst the room around them goes to weeds and roots. Frontier towns honour them. Polite cities eat their grain and keep them at arm's length. A Given Taken-In grew up in it. A Struck Taken-In was lost and dying in the deep wild, and the wild kept them.

A Phoenix is one person alive in the world. The wings are fire. They can be furled, and in a room, for a while, the person can pass, but the moment they leave the ground anyone who has heard the stories knows who went overhead. They die and rise, and each rising costs a Hope slot and a piece of who they were. The death that would cross out the last slot is the last one. Then, somewhere, a white-fire leaf falls for one child. Almost nobody has met them. They are known through stories. Do not put one in a party unless the whole table wants a campaign that keeps arriving at that person's door.

The people who keep the rites

You will meet these as jobs before you meet them as theologies.

The tree-wardens tend the town Tree, speak the colour at the Leaf-Fall, and rule on the rare and mixed falls. A town-warden may be a sincere skeptic and still be good at the work, because the wood is mortal and the common colours are already known. The First Seat, in the Motherwood, is a college, not a throne. It confirms the rare readings and authorizes cuttings. It does not appoint every town-warden, and it does not own the grove as a crown. Road-hands carry the wood. A cutting without their paper is how a kitchen-knife slip starts.

The Watchers keep a night of attention and will not let the mother-name start the history. They will sit beside a warden and describe a leaf: stem, edge, how it turned, whether the child flinched. They will not speak the colour as confirmed. Description is not a Speaking. In Threnmaieth a second reading is a column the crown would like to count. A Watcher who lets the withheld line stand is, to that crown, a problem. To the Watcher it is the point.

The Book-Hands witness, copy, stamp, and date. Marriage, a hull, a year's closing. They will not hide a clause. On Naenor they share the square with the tree-tenders and do not say the same sentence. The warden calls the colour a gift. The Book-hand calls it a debt. They do not rewrite a Bound person's terms. Those belong to the other party in the contract. Anyone who sells an easing of a clause in a cellar is a liar, or a thief of coin.

The Door-Keepers walk water, hill, and stone, in that order, and they leave food. They ask to be known, not Given. At an ancestor-meal they speak the names and keep the empty place from being sat in. That empty place is not a Returned person's chair. A different door. When a Struck person is brought to the threshold that made them, a door-keeper names them kin. A warden may, the same week, want them acknowledged at a Tree. The fight is which name goes first.

The Table-Keepers are the isle's version of a clergy, and a thin one. The work is the extra place. On the mainland, an attic that keeps the same supper is a guest-room, not a mission with a stamp.

The Pourers, the Walled Book, and the Protectors are not these houses, and they are not each other. You already have the Close. The Pourers are the circle a Long-Lived person is asked to join once. The Protectors are a rumour, in anything a player hears, about people who catch a Phoenix fire. Leave the method in the world book's GM chapter until you mean to use it.

A week, in three weathers

The same Leaf-Fall is a different week depending on where the child stands.

In Maiethlir the week is a holy day and a registration. The colour is sung and then written. A marriage that would pass an animal down a bloodline is noticed. The medicine is excellent and it runs through the crown. A household whose upkeep and bloodline are both on file cannot easily refuse the crown anything, and the faith supplies the reason: you would not hide a gift from the Mother, so why hide it from her stewards. Down the river, in Seinbrun, the same week is a hymn without a clerk. The colour is spoken and not copied. The Kept child is pitied at the feast, in a country where the Trees are not scarce and the pity is therefore a choice. In Rothallo the week belongs to the visiting warden who comes in to speak the fall, and to the Book that copies it afterward if it copies it at all. A hugged Closed child stays on the heir-roll. A coloured

Closed child does not. Outside the wall, Orenbren is counting beds, not colours, and charging for them. A pilgrim who cannot pay the First-Hand year still needs the week, and the upper room has learned what a bed is worth in Eolthael.

On the Ledger Coast the week is a milestone. Orentel watches a family's Leaf-Fall for what guild the colour opens. It is not warm. It is free, and it is prosperous, and the queue outside the Stilled infirmary is the longest in the world because the medicine is here and the price is here. At Naenor the same week is a festival and a signing. The Bound witness sits with their back to the Tree, which the city will not explain, and a household that still calls the colour a gift is already a risk on a ledger. At Lunbra the week produces a row. Who Turned, who can be found, which house pays. There is no hymn to appeal to if the row is wrong. At Raitin the week is local to the hearth, and a person vouched in the city can still be unknown in the next town. At Braetu the week is a quote. A hull, a lamp, a name that might not come back. The First-Hand year is assembled out of other people's desks.

In Eolvaeth the week, when the Tree speaks at all, is the event of a decade. The camp-streets fill. The Kept child is felt as a verdict. When the Tree does not speak, the wet leaf on the spring is the whole rite, and the gospel says stay. In Sanbreo there may not be a week worth the name. A hull pays, a neighbour slides, and Vathne's sentence is still on the wall. At Harrow's Green the week belongs to other people's children as much as to the town's. The hamlets send their ten-year-olds up the rise, and the town lives inside a sentence the Seat already wrote. At the First Bowl the week cannot start, if the keepers are doing it right, until the bowl has gone around. A warden who speaks first has already lost the argument about who the host is. At Ndenjoo there is no week. There is a bright night, an extra place, and a moon.

If you can feel those weeks as the same festival, you have the world. The law is largely the same law. The Tithe is the same upkeep. The difference is what the town thinks the week is for: a count, a hymn, a bed, a price, a signature, a wait, a meal, or a table with no tree.

How the world got here

People keep two clocks, and the clock a person reaches for tells you where they stand.

One clock is personal. It asks how you were Turned. Did you walk to Thaeloren, or to a neighbour who had already walked, or did you stand under a town Tree? A family will say they are a Hands-house, and that grandmother still talks of the road. A Long-Lived person who says "I walked" is saying when they were young, because they are old enough for the walk to have been their own childhood.

The other clock is geographic, and it has not finished. The Grafting is the carrying of living wood outward from the origin. The wood filled Maiethorn, crossed the sea to Strandoren, and is still arriving on Heskoren. Kumbaan never received it. Thin country is not a scar history left behind. It is the front of a job that is still being done.

Both clocks sit on a time nobody named. Before anyone counted years, the Awakening Tree already stood in the country now called the Sacred Core. People were already born into Kinds. Some were already Struck at a drowning, a grove, or a stone, far from any ceremony. Under the Tree, children in their tenth year were already brought at the solstice and either Given a colour or hugged. Nobody wrote down a king or a founding from that time. The Watching call it the Before, and they will not let a clerk scratch a Cut-year into the old stones. The Old Ways on Heskoren say their doors are older than any road to the Tree. Kumbaan does not count its past by the Tree at all.

Then families organised the trip. That stretch has no start-year. People call it the Walking Years, and the liturgical name is Brenvaeth, the hearth gone to waiting. There was one Tree and one week. A child who missed Turning-Week was not Given that year or any later year. They could still be Struck. They would never be Given. Families on Maiethorn walked the Near Mile, three to twelve days. Families on Strandoren took a ship across the Old Crossing, three to five days in fair weather, and then the Near Mile, usually one to three weeks in all. Families on Heskoren, and in the far inland of Strandoren, took the Long Mile, six to twelve weeks. A family that could not send every child sent one. That child might come home carrying a Condition. The siblings who stayed grew up without one, and folk called them Kept.

Inns sold the beds and the credit. Many of the innkeepers were Long-Lived, and they forgot none of what was owed. After the walk stopped being necessary, some of those inns became banks. The White Note House on Orentel's third quay is one of them. The Third Hearth, three days out from the grove, stayed an inn. Children died on the road, of rivers in thaw, fever in the

inns, late storms on the Crossing, and hunger on the Long Mile. The stones set over them are the mile-shrines still standing, often with a ribbon.

Reaching the Tree was not enough. A group of families with no Condition lived around the grove and decided who might stand under it. People call them the Closed Seat, and in ordinary talk the Grove-Sitters. A family needed a paper called grove-leave. A child could walk the whole Long Mile and go home unTurned because the gate refused them. The Closed Seat ruled the country around the Tree. It never ruled Strandoren. Heskoren was too far. Kumbaan never came.

In Cut-year 0 someone cut living wood from the Awakening Tree, carried it a day's walk in earth, and planted it, and it grew. Nobody knows who cut, and the town is not named. People call that first graft the nameless green. A new graft cannot hold a Leaf-Fall for about a generation. For nineteen years nobody knew whether the nameless green would ever Turn a child. Other towns cut anyway. Most cuttings died. The First Seat, the college of tree-wardens in the Motherwood, called the cutting theft and forbade it.

In Cut-year 19 the nameless green held its own Turning-Week. The stories disagree about colour or hug. Either way, a town that was not the origin had Turned its own child. The Seat stopped forbidding cuts and took charge of them. Permission to cut is Cutting-leave. The waiting list of towns that want a graft is the scion-queue. Both still exist. The Seat's minute from that summer says it will write down how a cutting is done and will not write down who did the first one.

The Closed Seat's power depended on being the only gate to the only Tree. From Cut-year 19 to 38 they sent riders to dig the new grafts up or burn them in their pots. They failed. Towns hid cuttings in wells and watered them at night. The lodging-towns would not starve a season of beds to help a gate. The First Seat would not help burn a graft that had already Turned a child. People call this the Closing, and folk who watched the riders call it the Uprooting. The remnant that still keeps the book says the Retreat.

In Cut-year 38 Hildal, a clerk and the last person of that gate whose name is still used, ordered the move. The Closed families left the grove, went a day's walk into a walled city, and took their Book. The city is Rothallo, still called the Inner Close. The Book ranks who owes. It is not a church, and it does not rule anyone outside the walls. The lodging-towns became Orenbren. The First Seat kept the right to say who may cut. Nobody controls who may stand under Thaeloren anymore.

The grafts then moved in the only order the wood allows. A cutting survives a short trip before it survives a long one, and a town Tree has to grow for about twenty years before it can give cuttings of its own. Maiethorn's core had Trees by about Cut-year 80. The dry east beyond the Rain-Wall was slower, and some families there still walk west. Strandoren's rich ports paid for a ship and a leave in the same summer, from about Cut-year 40 to 160, and got wood while some Maiethorn villages were still waiting. Then, from about 160 to 200, no graft reached Heskoren. Cuttings died on the long road. The Seat's list served towns that could pay. Heskoren did not wait because its people were unworthy, whatever a preacher in the Waiting Lands may say. From Cut-year 200 to now, wood has been arriving on Heskoren's coast. Harrow's Green got a graft in the 200s and has Turned its own children for a few generations. The three hamlets that can see Harrow's canopy from the ford are still waiting. No graft has crossed the storm-wall around Kumbaan.

Other years happened while the wood moved. They are not another age. They are the grudges people still charge.

In Cut-year 67 the hymn-country of the Sacred Core split over whether to write people down. Limrae opened a desk and said a person you cannot find again is a person you cannot look after. Manril refused to be named, and said a person belongs because they were seen to Turn. No battle. Households chose a desk. The side that kept the list became Threnmaieth. The side that refused became Maiethvael. Threnmaieth counts from that summer, so Cut-year 387 is Crown-year 320 there.

In Cut-year 171 a fever started in the holds and went through the ports on both sides of the Old Crossing. People call it the Grey Summer, and the docks call it the Salt-Grey. It was a disease, not a Tithe. It killed people who had a Tree and a ticket. Long-Lived bankers did not die. Their borrowers did, and the debts passed to the families. Afterward Trenledd began a list of who was still alive to be found. In Cut-year 174 the small towns of Brenledd put their charters into one league so nobody could price them one hearth at a time. Leddvael made the signing of a contract a public ceremony, because so many witnesses had died.

In Cut-year 233 the snow on Lirorn's Rain-Wall melted in one week. Valleys flooded. The old high road, the Noon Pass, went under. Narol of the Pass took the toll onto the lower road, the Shelf-gate, and Narol's house still collects it. A graft on its way to Ornled died because the cart

was late. Vathne wrote on a wall that the town would not wait with a hymn for a stick that drowned in someone else's thaw. Ornled still copies that sentence.

In Cut-year 248, at Harrow's Green, a warden announced copper-green for a child the Tree had hugged, because the town wanted one of the Taken-In. The green did not take. A Speaker corrected it two years later. People call the year the Wrong Green, and they still use it to teach a warden not to announce the colour a town wishes it had.

From Cut-year 299 to 304 the Hinge Shore and the Ledger Coast fought over who set the price of the crossing. In 304 they agreed a peace that names no winner. One charge remains, the Hush-rate. The Hinge Shore may bless. The Ledger Coast writes the paper. The same peace lets Saelvaeth take a graft without paying Vaethorn a blessing-fee, lets Vaethorn bless a landing and not tax it, and leaves Ornled free to charge a fee on its own beach.

That is the present. A town Tree is the ordinary way to Turn, and the wave is still moving. A child on the Long Mile this summer is making the week, not commemorating it. Kumbaan is off both clocks.

Maiethorn

Maiethorn is the old heart, the continent people mean by the centre. The name is the Mother's Land, spoken almost the way the hymns say it. The Awakening Tree stands here. The Trees are old and many. A child's Turning is least remarkable because it is most certain. Deathless houses, Stilled infirmaries, and Far-Voiced voices in the courts are ordinary infrastructure. If the rest of the world is that fullness thinning as you travel west, Maiethorn is the thick end.

It is not peaceful for being holy. Living next to the grove is pressure. Six powers share one fallen gate and the oldest trade route in the world, the Old Crossing, and they are still competing for both.

Threnmaieth, the Tallied Crown, sits nearest the sacred centre and wants every person written down. The roll is the Threnhael. At home it is called care of the Mother's gifts. From outside it is a census of persons, and only one other power keeps anything like it. The seat is Maiethlir, a thaw-river city one or two days from the wood, on a different road from the pilgrim inns. The city's own Tree Turns the city's children. The grove is a dark on the horizon, and the crown does

not own it. The First Seat stays in the clearings. Rithim speaks the colour in the square. A clerk waits at the other end of the same street and copies the fall onto the roll. A hymn and a line, in one afternoon. The crown provides the green, the novelty, the halls, and the medicine, generously, and it can withhold them. To be cut off is framed as your lapse. The Kept are pitied and recorded as passed over. The crown does not trust the three things the rest of the world uses as proof: a Long-Lived person's memory, a Bound person's word, and a Far-Voiced person's feeling. Those answer to themselves. A ledger answers to the crown.

Maiethvael, the Gift-Realm, sings the same hymns and keeps the opposite paper. In Cut-year 67 Manril would not be named. The capital is Seinbrun, off the river, more than a day north of Maiethlir. You can leave Maiethlir by the Down Gate, spend the day among Gift-folk, and still not have arrived. There is no list of persons. Congregation and guild furnish the hall, the green, and the medicine. Vuthbraen keeps the hall. Raermu keeps the medicine basket. To be inside the hymn is to be inside the net. Leave the hymn and the green, the hall, and the basket go together, and there is no crown to appeal to. The Kept are pitied here in the middle of plenty. The Trees are not scarce. The pity has no thin-country excuse. It is a slight the city teaches anyway, because it likes to say a hug is rare.

Orenbren, the Witness-Hearths, is the lodging-country of the Near Mile. It began as inns and became a country without becoming a church. It houses the people still walking toward the grove, and it charges for the bed in coin, in duty, or in hymn. It does not own Thaeloren, and it does not copy colours onto a roll. Its capital is Rothallo, one day's walk from the wood, still called the Inner Close. The Closed Heirs live inside the walls and keep the Book of Tithes. Delamem will tell you the Book is housekeeping. The page that assigns labour is in the same hand as the page that assigns a tax. At a Closed meal the Kept sit nearest the host. A guest with a Condition is shown to the far end. When two people disagree in front of a clerk and one is Kept, the clerk writes the Kept account as what happened and the other as "also said." Only a Kept person holds a key to a gate, a cistern, or the Book's house. Volnai, at the school beside the Book's house, teaches the children that a hug is rare and that a hugged child was kept back for something better. Volnai believes it. The count says otherwise. A Closed heir who receives a colour is struck off the roll. Talnin is on that roll this year and has not yet stood.

The inns outside Rothallo's wall lodge anyone. The Book rules inside. They share a country and they do not share a page. Threnmaieth would like the lodging-rolls. Orenbren records who slept.

Along that same road, three days out, Thilim keeps the Third Hearth. Thilim is Long-Lived and has kept the house since before clerks had a year to start from. The neighbour town, Brenthael, has its own Tree, and its children Turn at home. The Mile goes on past it. A stone that marks a day's walk stands in the inn's yard because Thilim would not let the town pull it into the square. Brenthael's warden wants it moved. At Brenthael's Turning-Week supper the Kept still sit nearest the Tree, and a child who has just received a colour gets up and moves outward before the food. Nobody there can say when that started.

Two days past Brenthael, the Mill-hold's Tree is standing in water. The culvert choked this thaw, the mill-race stayed full, and the roots are drowning. It is horticulture, not a curse. A warden who lets this year's children stand under that Tree spends their one week. The neighbour's canopy, at Brenthael, is where they have to go, if Brenthael's week still has room. Milsun, Talen, and Thurrei are the drain, the race, and the wood. A Road-hand who arrives is there for the wood, not for the children.

A day short of the Third Hearth, a spur leaves the Mile and does not rejoin it. Nelath is where that spur stops. The stone that used to stand a day further on now sits in the square, and beyond the boughs there is a ditch of thorns where the road was. Raetoth will not read the name cut in the stone. Lithsur will, and wants the stone put back on the scar so the name is a day's mark again. A pilgrim may leave a ribbon. A family in need turns around and uses the Mile.

East of the Rain-Wall the country dries. Saelthael, the Sown Tree, is still walking west after the core stopped. Larbril is the city where the west road meets the Well-wash, short of the pass. Brormei says what the wash is this week, a river or a line of silt, and whether a column goes on. Ornsael is the smaller well-town farther into the dry. The Tree there speaks most years. The well is what is failing. Fox-born hearths are dense because it is sand-country, not because the city is a fox nation. Core pilgrims who arrive expecting a holiday find a necessity they thought belonged to Heskoren. They were not wrong about waiting. They were wrong about what is waited for.

The Rain-Wall itself is Lirorn, the Thaw-Land. Lowlanders call the range the Rain-Wall. The people on it call it the Thaw-Wall. Tasain is the walled town in the valley below the Shelf-gate, where the west road comes down and the levy is taken. The Noon Pass is the old high road, and

the water-line of Cut-year 233 still sits on its stone. Narol is dead. The house still says the toll is Narol's. Maiethlir drinks the same snowmelt downstream and files a loud week as weather. That filing is not a receipt for this gate. Tengu and Fox-of-the-Snows live on the high snow. The valley is mixed. The office at the gate is the levy, not a people.

The west coast faces Strandoren across the Old Crossing. Votaer, the Hinge Shore's port, sorts a hull before anyone across the water prices it. Tumair writes what the ship is: a child, a pot of living earth, a person a contract has come to hold, a family on a neighbour's week. Lertho charges the Hush-rate on the same water. The grove is still at the city's back, which is why the quay is rich and less frantic than Orentel. A blessing and a docket happen in the same breath. A household can fail in sight of the road to the grove while a hymn is still in the air.

What Maiethorn thinks of the rest is simple, and it is proud. The centre is here. The shore has learned to price the holy. Heskoren is still on the road. The isle is a sailor's story, and the Seat does not write it as a land to graft.

Strandoren

Strandoren is the witnessed shore, close enough to Maiethorn for the crossing to be the oldest argument in the world, and far enough for the faith and the old *th* to have worn off the docks. People call the two continents the Old World pair because the water made them into one argument. There is no single crown. Five powers share a Salt Walk that outlived the grove-gate, and a fever that made them write new paper.

Lestrand, the Ledger Coast, is the premier coast, seated at Orentel. Coast-folk say the Salt Quay and mean the city. The Trees are mature. The Given are dense. The faith is worn lightly. The state is a charter-council of houses and guilds. It charters a guild and watches the guild, never the person. There is no roll of souls. In a city this large, the witness that you belong is a hearth: the quay-gang or the courtyard that actually saw you Turn, not twenty thousand people sharing one memory. A Long-Lived notary, a Bound person's sworn word, and a Far-Voiced witness are infrastructure. They are not reverence. The gate asks your name, your last hearth, and who stands for you. It does not ask your colour. An unvouched person is a transaction that cannot clear.

Orentel is built on a hill, and the hill is the city's argument. At the top, the Rise, the city's own children are Turned for free. At the bottom, the first quay, berths are held in Eolthael for households who can pay to walk a walk they do not need. That product is a First-Hand year. Sorim assigns the empty berths. The White Note, on the third quay, writes the terms and does not wear the crown. Ledan asked the Seat, in Cut-year 280, which year to put on a hundred-year loan, because the bank, the town, and the Seat each counted differently. The bank still converts the way that letter did. Cut-year 387 is the White Note's 307th year. A family can stand on the street between the Rise and the quay, the Drop, and see both prices in one glance. The Taken-In rent leaf-lots by the season. Selkie families work the water. Neither is the city's flag. If you cannot pay, the city will not file you and it will not catch you. You fade, and the city feels it owed you nothing.

Brenledd, the Hearth-League, sits its council at Raitin, a river-city inland of the salt. It is a league of hearths, not one house. Where Orentel prices a berth, Raitin clears a note among towns. You are of your town first. Six charter-towns sit around the city and are not named. People still recite Nidtol when Lestrand offers to deal with one ruler instead of seven hearths. Nidtol is the hearth that made the league's first shared refusal, in Cut-year 174, after the fever. It is not a person in the hall, and it is not Raitin. Turvo keeps the shared notes. A note can clear in this hall and still die in the next hearth. The league calls that gap local.

Leddvael, the Reckoned Gift, made the Fair Hand into civic life. The port is Naenor, on its own stretch of coast, not facing the Hinge Shore. Leaf-Fall here is a festival and a signing-watch at once. A Tithe is a term being serviced. The Bound are employed to witness, because a Bound person's word still closed in the Grey Summer when the other witnesses had died. Derdil stands the watch. The city will file a contract. It will not copy Threnmaieth's list. It wins the signing and loses the berth: the empty prestige berths, the White Note, and the great deathless houses are still Orentel's. A household that calls a colour a gift, rather than a term, is filed as a credit risk. The Bound are safe here, and they are over-read, because a contract is being asked to stand for the whole person.

Trenledd, the Worn Count, keeps a roll of persons at Lunbra, four to eight days up the Chart-run from Orentel. The city shows its money, in stone fronts and guild doors left open so the coin is visible from the street. The roll is how a person is allowed near that money. There is no hymn

that makes the list a stewardship. Threnmaieth at least claims to keep you hale. Trenledd claims to keep you findable. After the Grey Summer, Dirrol's column was who is still alive. Dirrol is not a living clerk. Vamar keeps the page of who owes, who Turned, and who can be found. The office that could strike a row stays unnamed. The Struck are pursued so they can be written down, because an unwitnessed change is a row that appeared without a clerk. Cutting a person off the furnished channels is the default, and it is not called impiety.

Netstrand, the Night Shore, faces the west water from Braetu. It is smaller than Orentel because the far run is thinner than the Old Crossing. The city does not sell a finished First-Hand year. It charters the hull. The White Note writes the terms. Orentel holds the berth. Braetu is the first of those three desks. A crossing toward Heskoren takes two to four weeks in fair weather. Beyond the last capes is the storm-wall, and Kumbaan is not booked from this quay. The harbour keeps a dark book of quoted crossings that did not come back. Houses pay to keep a lamp on a name. Mursur writes the far figure and takes the fee for the lamp. One berth stays unlit, with no house attached to it, and the city will not add one to make the book tidy. The lamp is sold as watch. It is not a roll of souls, and it is not grief the quay will admit.

What Strandoren thinks of Maiethorn is that the extra mile is a product, the grove is a season you can buy, and the hymns are optional. What the five think of each other is a fight about paper. Orentel prices. Raitin refuses to be priced hearth by hearth. Naenor signs. Lunbra finds you. Braetu watches for the hull that does not come back. What they think of Heskoren is the next cargo, and a frontier that still needs a week. What they think of the isle is a tale. They do not book it.

Heskoren

Heskoren is the outer land, spoken Heskorn when the old *th* has been worn down and put back only in a prayer. It was reached late and grafted late. Between Strandoren and Heskoren the sea widens into the West Water. People call what begins on the far shore the frontier. Four powers, a long wild between the Trees, and host-rights that were already on the ground when the wood arrived. Waiting, sowing, and a slate are three answers to the same late cart.

Vaethorn, the Waiting Lands, is the hot faith of a country where the gift is scarce. The seat is Eolvaeth, folk-shortened to Elvaeth, a vale behind the coast that faces Strandoren. Vaethod

keeps the square. A couple of thousand people live there in an ordinary month, and more when the roads fill. The graft is from the Cut-year 200s. It speaks in some years and never became a neighbour's certainty. The live front moved on. The waiting stayed, and the congregation made a country of the staying. There is almost no state. Custom outruns written law. You can walk in, someone will feed you, and no clerk will write you down. The green a Taken-In person needs is a neighbour's duty. The venting a Far-Voiced person needs happens at worship. Medicine is a travelling stiller if the town is lucky. The Kept are felt most sharply here, because in a land starved of the gift, to be hugged and left without a colour is read, wrongly, as being passed over by the Mother. The harm is not a boot. It is guilt. The gospel wants the neighbours on either side, Ornled and Saelvaeth, to be unworthy of the wood. The history of the planting does not agree. Children leave a wet leaf on the lip of the spring in a year the Tree does not speak. There is nothing on the hill to climb, which disappoints visitors from the core.

Ornled, the Outer Ledger, has the same thin Trees and no congregations. The town is Sanbreo, on the west slate-shore, toward the last capes. A walk that used to pass through left stones and upper rooms, and people still sleep in them. The brink did not grow a hymn and did not grow a counted hall. The first line on the shore-gate wall is still Vathne's, recopied onto newer wood: the town will not wait with a hymn for a stick that drowned in someone else's thaw. When a hull comes round the capes, whoever is on the gate that day cuts a beach-fee on the same slate. Vaethorn may bless that landing and may not tax it. Ornled takes the fee anyway, because a hull is a hull. An unvouched Struck person is met with a rope, a deal, or a neighbour. There is no blessing queued behind the fee. Vaethorn hears godlessness. The wall hears a luxury that died in a cart.

Vaelhesk, the Far Yield, did not build a capital. The land is the seat. Old greens, ancestor-doors, and a first meal before anyone leaves with something of the place: that is the country. A traveler who asks for the seat is pointed at a door. The First Bowl, folk name Lonasir, is a guest-grove in that country, not a city. A young Tree stands in an old green, cut from Harrow's after Harrow's own Tree took. The meal is older than the Tree. Vilraet speaks the colour, or tries to, after the bowl has gone around. Delvor keeps the bowl. Brudu keeps the morning water, and the fight over a bucket is host against guest in the same green. A Cutting-leave that arrives without the meal is a claiming. A warden who sits and eats is a guest. A warden who takes the wood without sitting is a thief. The Door-Keepers here name a Struck person kin at the door that made them.

They do not confirm colours, and they did not carry the cutting. Vaethorn reads a child who will not walk to a Motherfaith Tree as Kept for want of a gift. The Yield reads that child as already the hill's. The disagreement decides whether the child travels.

Saelvaeth, the Sown Waiting, is the march on the moving edge. Natai is the town, west of Harrow's Green on the roads toward Sanbreo, and not on the ford. Dumu stands the gate and answers for the queue of grafts. Dumu cannot decide where a pot goes. The office exists because someone has to be the person a neighbour can shout at. Harrow's has the canopy. Natai has the blame. The Hinge Hush lets this march take a pot without paying Vaethorn a waiting-due. The due that remains is local.

Harrow's Green is the luckiest square on this continent, and it is not the capital. A cutting arrived in the Cut-year 200s, spoke a generation later, and has Turned local children for a few generations. New towns everywhere still say they Turned at Harrow's Tree before they had their own. Here that sentence is the decade, not an old story. Haelin is the warden. A few hundred hearths sit on a low rise above the Rise-water. There are no walls. The square is the last holy mile, and beyond the boughs the old way is a cart-track to the ford. Children are told the road goes to the Motherwood. It goes to the mill, and then to three hamlets that can see the canopy. Both are true if you keep walking. There is no resident stiller. A travelling one is a summer's luck.

The Three Hamlets Past the Ford are Brenod, Vaelun, and Ornath. The Seat's paper still says "the three hamlets past the ford," and it has already written that the wood will take at Harrow's and will not take this year at the hamlets, because the soil is thin. You walk from kitchen to kitchen. You do not walk through a town. This year's ten-year-olds go to Harrow's, or further if Harrow's week is full, or still the Long Mile if the neighbour is only a stick in a pot. A child may stay Kept at the ford while a sibling walks. Old Ways hearths may refuse the neighbour's week on purpose. Motherfaith neighbours read those children as Kept for want of a gift. Tora of Brenod keeps the walk from the ford. The hamlets can hear all four powers at once: Saelvaeth's canopy, Vaethorn's gospel, Vaelhesk's refusal in the kitchen, and Ornled's slate if they walk the other way. They have learned not to say queue. A kitchen-knife and a failed slip are not a rebellion. Most slips die.

What Heskoren thinks of the core is that you have Trees, and we are still waiting. What it thinks of Strandoren is that your paper does not grow a canopy, though it will charter the hull that brings a pot. What the four think of each other is the late cart. Vaethorn says stay and be worthy. Ornled says the stick drowned and the hymn did not save it. Vaelhesk says sit down before you cut. Saelvaeth says someone has to answer for the line. Harrow's did not ask to be the sentence the Seat already wrote.

If you stay a month

A week shows you the festival. A month shows you the harm, and the harm is how you will know you are running the right country.

Stay a month in Threnmaieth and the generosity gets heavy. The green, the new book, the hall-hour, and the surgeon all arrive, and they arrive through hands the crown can close. A Taken-In person who needs a night on living ground, a Long-Lived person who needs a page they have not read, a Far-Voiced person who needs a room to let a feeling out, all of them receive it as the Mother's bounty. If the channel closes, the town will say the lapse was yours. Marriages that pass an animal down a line are encouraged or discouraged and then filed. The Struck are looked for so they can be catalogued, not so they can be hated in the open. The Bound are watched far past the real danger, because the whisper can suggest and the clerks know it cannot command, and the roster watches them anyway. You will feel, by the end of the month, that faith and plenty are excusing each other. There is no clean villain. Orderly people believe that accounting for a gift is the highest way to tend it.

Stay a month in Maiethvael and the warmth is real, and so is the bill. Nobody writes your name. The hall feeds you, the lots are tended, the medicine basket opens. Then watch a household leave the hymn. The pots go into the lane. The latch on the basket is opened before the knock, which is Raermu's habit, and it is also the whole polity: care, and then the condition of the care. The Kept are loved and measured in the same sentence. Threnmaieth at least files them. Maiethvael cannot stop telling them what they missed, in a land where a hug is common and the Trees are healthy. If you fall out of the congregation there is no crown to appeal to. The net was the hymn.

Stay a month in Orenbren and you will learn the price of a bed. The inns are kind. They lodged the Closing by refusing to starve a pilgrim season, and they are proud of that, and they have learned what an upper room is worth in the month the children stand. A family that came for the grove and cannot pay the First-Hand year still needs the week. The slate is the unkindness, wearing the face of hospitality. Inside Rothallo the month teaches a different rank. You will see who sits nearest the host, who holds the cistern key, whose account is written as what happened and whose is written as "also said." People with a Condition work for wages, marry whom they choose, and can leave on any day the gate is open. They are not slaves. What they cannot have inside the walls is the heir's place, the gate key, and the first word in front of a clerk. Volnai will teach the children the hug is rare. You know the count. Let the school be wrong in the open. That wrongness is the Close.

Stay a month in Lestrand and nothing is policed and everything is priced. Your marriage, your gift, and your faith are your own. A Two-Bodied bloodline is a trade. A Long-Lived match is a century of credit. The Turning is watched for which guild the colour opens. The Stilled infirmaries and the deathless hospitals are the best in the world, and the queue outside them is the world's verdict on a rich city. If the party can pay, the month is frictionless: a road-word at the gate, a guild-mark, three questions and not a colour. If they cannot pay, the city steps around a fade and feels it owed nothing. The shadow market is the largest here because the honest market is the largest here. Smuggled green, novelty off the book, a vouching that was sold. A Bound person who has signed away enough of themselves that the other party effectively holds them is fed by that market. The deathless houses do not die and do not disperse. A handful of them steer the wealthiest coast by patronage. The White Note is one of those desks. It is not the crown. Do not let a player treat it as the government.

Stay a month in the Waiting Lands and the kindness is the first thing, and the loneliness is the second. There is little to fund the charity the gospel requires. Neighbours furnish the green and call it sacred. A Far-Voiced person vents at worship because there is no hall. A travelling stiller is a decade's luck. An unvouched Struck person, changed alone with no guild to catch them, meets a rope or a blessing more often than a licence, because there is no guild to issue one. The Kept wonder what they lacked. The gospel is willing to agree with them. That agreement is the harm. It is not a boot. It is a quiet piety that shades want into a spiritual failing. Eolvaeth will

feed a stranger and will not call the feeding necessity, even when the stranger is there because they have to be.

Stay a month on the Far Yield and you will eat before you are allowed to leave with anything, including a cutting of wood. Refuse the meal and take the wood, and you are not a neighbour. The argument stays at the table. It does not become a holy war unless you push it there, and you should not. The Door-Keepers and the warden both love the wood. The fight is who the host is. Vaethorn, hearing that a child was not sent to a Motherfaith Tree, will call it deprivation. The Yield will call it kin. Both will be sincere.

Stay a month in Ornled and you will see the slide with no net under it. Roofs fill a pocket. A beach-fee is cut on a slate. A hymn is what Vaethorn sells, and this town heard a graft drown in someone else's thaw and stopped buying. An unvouched Struck person is a rope, a deal, or a neighbour. The loneliest version of that person on this coast is next door to a gospel and not inside it.

If the party crosses from one of these months into another, do not reset them with a speech about themes. Let the gate ask a different question. Maiethlir asks what you carry so it can be written. Seinbrun asks whether you are in the hymn. Rothallo asks where you sit. Orentel asks whether the transaction can clear. Eolvaeth asks you to stay. The First Bowl asks you to eat. Ndenjoo asks you to sleep when the moon is down.

How far the wood is, in the walking

You can feel the map without a map if you remember four journeys.

The Near Mile is three to twelve days from the grove, through Orenbren's inns. The Third Hearth is the third night out. Brenthael is a day past that, with its own Tree, and the road does not stop. The Mill-hold is two days past Brenthael. Nelath's spur leaves the Mile a day short of the Third Hearth and ends. Rothallo is a day from the wood on its own road. Maiethlir is one or two days from the wood on the river road, which is not the pilgrim mile. Seinbrun is more than a day beyond Maiethlir's Down Gate, off the water. These are not one city. A party that treats the Sacred Core as a single square will miss the argument, because the argument is which road they are on and who owns the page at the end of it.

The Old Crossing is three to five days of fair-weather sail between Votaer and Orentel. A late storm in the month the roads fill can make a family miss Turning-Week, and then the child stays unTurned. The Hinge Shore sorts the hull. The Ledger Coast prices it. Orenbren, if the party is going on to the grove, takes the sleep. Three desks, one crossing. From Orentel, Lunbra is four to eight days up the Chart-run. Raitin is a different river. Naenor is down the coast and does not face the hinge. Braetu is eight to fourteen days of coasting to the west water. The far run from Braetu toward Heskoren is two to four weeks. Beyond the last capes the storm-wall begins, and you do not book Kumbaan.

The Long Mile, when the neighbour was a continent, was six to twelve weeks. It is still that long when a hamlet's only Tree is a stick in a pot, or when a family on the Waiting still walks. Harrow's Green made the neighbour local. The hamlets can see it. Eolvaeth cannot, and does not want to. Sanbreo is the other coast of the same continent: a hull that wants that beach has come round the capes, not across the West Water in a straight line. The days between Harrow's, Natai, and Sanbreo are not written down. Do not invent a tidy itinerary. The uncertainty is the frontier.

The Rain-Wall is why Maiethorn has a wet side and a dry side. Tasain takes the levy where the west road comes down. Larbril is the city on the dry side, short of the pass if you are walking west. Ornsael is farther into the dust. Maiethlir drinks the melt and files a flood as snowmelt. The ridge paid for that water in Cut-year 233, and the toll is still said in Narol's name. Tengu live on the high snow because the air is theirs. They are not a country of the range.

Hear the distance in the speech. Nearest the Tree the old *th* stays. A frontier town wears it down and puts it back when someone prays, which is why Vaethorn is written with the sacred sound and spoken Wetorn. A dock sands it off, which is why Lestrand is the Reckoning Coast with the holy word worn out of the name, and why Trenledd will not say the reconstruction that would make their roll sound like Threnmaieth's. On Maiethorn the Mother-names cluster because the speech stayed. You can tell how far a speaker sits from the grove without asking for their papers.

What the fifteen inherited

Each power is younger than it sounds, and each one is still charging a year.

Threnmaieth inherited the Two Papers. Maiethvael inherited the refusal. They are the same split, and they will not share ink. Orenbren inherited the Closing's open beds and a guest-compact with the Retreat that put the Book behind a wall. Saelthael inherited slow grafts and the Thaw-Break, and it still walks west. The Hinge Shore inherited the crossing, the Grey Summer, and the Hush-rate. Lirorn inherited the watershed and Narol's pass, and the ridge still pays for water the valley files as a gift. Lestrand inherited Salt Walk paper that outlived the gate, notes that outlived the fever, and a peace that covers hulls and not the origin-winter. Brenledd inherited the compact of Cut-year 174 and will not be priced hearth by hearth. Leddvael inherited the public signing after the witnesses died, and a Bound contract counts there as honesty. Trenledd inherited Dirrol's column of who is still alive, and the roll is colder than the Threnhael because it does not pretend to be care. Netstrand inherited the west-water clause: hulls, not the prestige year. The night is a watch for ships that do not come. Vaethorn inherited the late wave. It may bless a landing and may not levy it, and the gospel still wants Ornled and Saelvaeth unworthy. Ornled inherited the refusal of that gospel and a beach-fee nobody asked them to invent. Vaelhesk inherited host-rights older than the wave. A first meal is not a landing-due. Saelvaeth inherited a live march from the Cut-year 200s. The queue is the border.

Rothallo remembers the Closed Seat, not a continent of its own. The belief that a hugged person ranks above a person with a colour survived the Retreat by three hundred and forty-nine years. It leaks. Some inns just outside the gate keep the best table for Kept guests when a Closed house dines. Brenthael, which has no copy of the Book, still seats the Kept nearest the Tree at the Turning-Week supper. Eolvaeth's gift-hall teaches that a colour and a hug are equal and says aloud that the Close is wrong. Given heirs who were struck off the roll eat there.

A clerk of the Seat and a factor on the Coast will not hand you the same list of the fifteen, and both lists are true of the speaker. The Seat's minute names Threnmaieth as the Reckoning that would name the Seat, Maiethvael as the cousin who will not be named and still gives the extra mile, Orenbren as the lodger, Saelthael as the walk the origin finds inconvenient, the Hinge Shore as the taker of the Crossing, Lirorn as the taker of the thaw. Across the water the factor's five are Lestrand, the Brenledd compact, Leddvael which files a Bound person as a civic virtue, Trenledd which keeps a roll and will not call it a Threnhael, and Netstrand which sells the west. On the far reach the Seat writes Vaethorn waiting, Saelvaeth planting, Vaelhesk feeding a first meal the Seat did not authorize, and Ornled which will not say her name and will not keep a list

either. Kumbaan, the minute says, is not a land we graft. The factor's docket is shorter and ruder. Price the hinge. Do not argue hymns with the Gift-Realm. The Witness-Hearths are a market calling itself a duty. Avoid the Worn Count. The Reckoned Gift will sign. The Night Shore quotes the far crossing like a pilgrimage. Heskoren pays in blessing, slate, a meal, or whatever the queue did this year. The isle is a tale. We do not book it.

Use those two voices when you need the world in a hurry. They are not complete. They are how the centre and the coast actually sort the same map.

Kumbaan

Kumbaan is not a sixteenth power. Sailors say the Sundering Isle, or the Sunder, for the weather that walls it off. The people who live there call it the hidden home. A girdle of storm, current, and reef wrecks most ships that try it. A thinning is a moon the shore-sitters know, not a date you can buy. Most hulls wreck, turn back, or do not return. No graft has crossed. A cutting planted here would die. Dead wood is not a Tree. The people count moons, not Cut-years. On the mainland they are a sailor's story. On the isle they are ordinary, and they are Yumboe because that is who lives there, not because an order requires it.

Ndenjoo, the Feeding Hill, is the hall the valley already uses. A few dozen hearths live under one green hill, pasture and standing-stones on the turf, the life in the rooms below. Njunda opens the hall because it was their grandmother's and it still holds the crowd. That is reputation, not an office. When Njunda dies, the valley will go to the next hall that still sets the extra place. The rite is supper. Every meal that matters sets one extra place, a little back from the end, not at the head. Leaving it unset is the one impiety. Hands no one can see fetch and pour. There are songs. Nobody reads a leaf. Daylight is for sleep. A mainlander who keeps noon as a holy hour, and who is loud while the hill is sleeping, is a problem the whole hall feels.

The beach is a walk down, not a dock. Soonke does not swim out after a wreck. If someone is alive, Soonke walks them up. The first night is as a guest, at the table, not on the sand. The second night, Njunda can say you are of the table. That kin does not travel home as papers. A mainland watch will not take it. Saalo wants a crossing out, toward Waandi, who left and sent no word. Nolas, off a Netstrand hull, has sat twice and will not go back to a ship. The valley is tired. You do not book Ndenjoo. You are on the sand or you are not.

On one night of the moon sailors call Yoltal, the hall eats the heel of the loaf first. Every other night the heel is last, or it goes to the goats. People say the hands like the crust when the mainland is loud. Njunda will not correct that, and will not say whether it is the reason. A guest who asks is given more bread. Do not invent the reason. The hall does not have one it will give you.

What the mainland thinks is that the isle is a tale, a wreck, a proverb someone will try to sell on a quay. What the hall thinks of a warden, a Book-hand, or a Watcher who crosses is that they are guests. First night, second night. There is no Tree to tend, no book to stamp, and no night watch to keep. Their noon-faith is loud.

How you know where a stranger is from

You do not need their papers. The world tells on them in small ways, and if you can hear those ways you can run a gate, a dock, or a supper without looking anything up.

Listen to the *th*. If it stays, the way it stays in Threnmaieth and Maiethvael and the Mother-names, the speaker was raised near the grove or is praying. If it comes and goes, worn down in ordinary talk and put back when the sentence turns holy, you are hearing Heskoren. Vaethorn written, Wetorn said. If the sound is simply gone, you are hearing a dock. Lestrand is the farthest drift of the old three. Trenledd will not restore the holy word, because restoring it would make their roll sound like the Tallied Crown's. A Yumboe name does not have that *th* at all. It sounds foreign on a mainland quay the moment it is spoken, and on Kumbaan it is the ordinary name.

Watch what they do with a leaf-fall. A Threnmaieth clerk waits to copy it. A Maiethvael neighbour waits to see whether the household is still in the hymn. A Watcher describes the leaf and will not say the colour as a fact. A Book-hand on Naenor hears a term. A Door-Keeper asks which door, and whether the person has been fed. A warden asks whether the week was this week, because a missed week is spent. A Closed heir asks whether the child was hugged. An Orentel factor asks which guild the colour opens. A Sanbreo gate does not ask. A Ndenjoo host does not have a tree to read.

Watch the upkeep, because the upkeep is the politics. If the green, the page, the hall-hour, and the surgeon all arrive through one channel, you are in a crown that can close the channel, and on this map that crown is Threnmaieth. If they arrive through a congregation and vanish when the household leaves the hymn, you are in the Gift-Realm. If you can buy them and the queue is long, you are on the Ledger Coast. If a neighbour furnishes them as alms and there is almost nothing to give, you are in the Waiting. If the furnishing is a meal before a cutting, you are on the Yield. If there is no furnishing and a slate by the beach, you are in Ornled. If the person is simply walked to a neighbour's Tree, you are at the hamlets or the Mill-hold, and the crisis is this week, not a philosophy.

Watch who sits where. Nearest the host, in a Closed house, means Kept. The far end means a Condition. On the Near Mile, at Brenthael's Turning-Week supper, the same rank has leaked onto the benches by the Tree, and nobody can say when it started. At the First Bowl the bowl goes around before anyone speaks a colour, and a warden who speaks first has already chosen a side. At Ndenjoo the extra place is slightly back from the end, and a child is told not to sit there. At Seinbrun an empty bowl sits away from the pot. At Raitin an empty cup sits at the end of the council table. Do not explain these. The people who set them will not.

Ask the three questions the gates already ask, and hear which one they care about. Name. Last hearth. Who stands for you. Orentel needs all three or the transaction cannot clear, and it does not need your colour. Threnmaieth has those three and then wants the gift on the roll. Eolvaeth may not ask at all, and will feed you, and will call the feeding devotion even when you came because your own Tree failed. The First Bowl asks whether you have eaten. Soonke, on the sand below Ndenjoo, asks only whether you are alive. Njunda asks, on the second night, whether you are of the table. A mainland watch will not accept Njunda's answer as papers. That refusal is the whole distance between the isle and the shore.

If a player asks what a place thinks of them, answer from the place, not from a moral. A Tallied clerk thinks an unlisted gift is a gift already failed. A Gift-Realm neighbour thinks a list is a failure of trust. A Ledger factor thinks an unvouched person is a deal that cannot close, and thinks a hymn is optional. A Waiting preacher thinks scarcity is a test, and is wrong about the worthiness, and sincere. A Yield host thinks a cutting without a meal is theft. A hamlet kitchen thinks the canopy on the far slope is this year's week, not a symbol. A Close clerk thinks a hug

outranks a colour, and the school is teaching that lie with a straight face. You can love all of these people and still let them be wrong in the particular way their country is wrong.

What they say about each other

These are the sentences you want in your head before a session. They are what a person from that place will actually grant. They are not fair, and they are not the whole truth. They are the weather.

A person from Threnmaieth says: we keep the Mother's gifts by writing them down, and a cousin who will not be named is failing the gift. The shore has priced what should be tended. The Waiting is sincere and poor. The isle is not a land we graft.

A person from Maiethvael says: we sing the same hymns and we will not keep their list. Counting a person is a failure of trust. The Close ranks who owes, which is someone else's book. The shore sells the extra mile. We furnish it.

A person from the Watching, in those same old districts, says: the Tree was already seeing before anyone called it a mother. We will describe the leaf. We will not confirm the colour, and we will not say she.

A person from Orenbren says: we kept the beds open when the gate wanted them shut. We house the walk. We do not own the grove, and we do not want the crown's tablets. The Book inside the Close is a guest-compact that never opened.

A person from the Close says: a hug is the better keeping, and the Book is housekeeping. The lodging-towns sell what we withdrew to save.

A person from Lestrand says: price the Hinge Shore and do not argue hymns with the Gift-Realm. The Witness-Hearths are a market that calls itself a duty. Avoid the Worn Count unless you like being written. The Reckoned Gift will sign, and that is cheaper than faith. Heskoren pays in blessing, in slate, in a meal you had better eat, or in whatever the queue did this year. The isle is a tale.

A person from Brenledd says: we will not be priced one hearth at a time, and we will not become one ruler so the Coast can have a single desk.

A person from Leddvael says: a gift is a term, and a Bound person's word held when the witnesses died. The Coast can keep the berth. We close the contract.

A person from Trenledd says: we can find you. The Tallied Crown dresses the same list as a hymn. We do not bother.

A person from the Night Shore says: we quote the far crossing the way you talk about a pilgrimage. We keep a lamp on the name that does not come back. We do not book the isle.

A person from the Hinge Shore says: we say what the hull is before they price it. The blessing and the rate are the same water. We did not win the war. We still charge the peace.

A person from Vaethorn says: the gift is scarce because we are still being tested. Stay. The march that takes a pot without our blessing is unworthy. The beach that charges and will not pray is empty. Harrow's luck is not our vale, and we do not want to see it, because wanting it would admit the wait is a queue.

A person from Ornled says: we will not wait with a hymn for a stick that drowned in someone else's thaw. Pay the beach. A blessing is not a net.

A person from the Far Yield says: sit the meal before you cut. A leave without the bowl is a theft. The Waiting calls our children ungifted. They are already the hill's.

A person from Saelvaeth says: someone has to stand where the queue can be shouted at. Harrow's has the canopy. We have the person you blame. The Waiting wants a fee we do not owe.

A person from Harrow's Green says: the neighbour's week is this decade, not a story. The Seat already wrote that the wood takes here and does not take at the ford. We did not ask to be that sentence.

A person from the hamlets says: we can see the canopy. We are still walking. Do not call it devotion. Do not call it a queue.

A person from Ndenjoo says: you have crossed drowning-water, so eat. Sit a second night and you are of the table. We have no tree to read your colour. Sleep when the moon is down. Your noon is loud.

Where you can set a party down

Use these as rooms, not as a tour. Each one already has an argument. You do not need a new town.

Maiethlir is a hymn at one end of Loft Row and a copy at the other. The beds between them are the old pilgrim rooms, and the roll has not found all of them. A family from thin up-country still sleeps in an uncounted loft. Rithim speaks the colour. The clerk is already waiting. The Motherwood is a dark on the horizon, and walking to it does not make the college a room in the city. The crown drinks the Core-thaw and does not own the snow that made it.

Seinbrun is the furnished hall. An empty bowl sits at the end of the table, away from the pot, and is cleared when the others are cleared. The city will not say why it was set. A household that leaves the hymn has its green pots stacked in the lane with the plants still in them. Breillai left, and the green went, and Breillai is still in the city. The hall can still set a bowl. The net stays where the hymn is.

Rothallo is a gate. A person who thought the Close was an inn finds the wall. Inside, Delamem's Book assigns the turns. Volnai's school is teaching the wrong count with a straight face. Talnin has not stood yet. If a colour falls, the heir's place goes. Outside the wall the inns lodge anyone, and some of them still move a Conditioned guest when a Closed house asks for the best table. The Low Wall, in the lodging-fields, is a different quarry and an older stone. The Close will claim it. Scratch the lichen and the claim fails. Children climb it the way they climb a shrine. It is not a shrine.

The Third Hearth still asks who will be here at dark. Thilim can tell a devotion from a necessity from a prestige and will not always tell you. Brenthael wants the day-stone moved into its own square. The Mile goes on past both of them.

The Mill-hold is a shovel and a neighbour-slate. The Tree is standing in the race. This year's children have to be walked to Brenthael, two days grove-ward, if there is room. A bough coming down, mill-foam on the lip, or one name too many on the slate is the scene.

Nelath is the last mile pulled into the square. The stone is here. The road beyond the boughs is a scar. Raetoth will not say which bed is the next day, because there isn't one. Lithsur wants the name back on a day of walking.

Larbril is the meeting of the west road and a wash that might be a river and might be a silt-line. Brormei wets the meeting-stone from a jar when the wash is dry, and will not say why. A cart bound west is held while the driver sets a pebble on the dry line. Ornsael, farther into the dust, is arguing about buckets. The Dry Stair above a lesser well-town climbs to a door with no wall and a basin that does not hold water. A warden planted a slip there once. It died. The town points west when a visitor asks where the Tree is, and then someone laughs.

Votaer writes the hull under the waterline, where the next tide takes the chalk. Lertho counts the Hush-rate aloud, sets the last coin in the box, and takes it out once before it stays. A blessing and a docket in the same breath. A Tithe-poor household can fail in sight of the road inland while the hymn is still going.

Orentel is the Drop. Free colour at the top, held berths at the bottom. The White Note is a desk on the third quay, north side. It is not the council. Necessity still eats in the lofts, and someone files that as occupancy. If the party has coin, the city is frictionless. If they do not, the city steps around them.

Raitin clears a note and may still lose it in the next hearth. One cup at the end of the council table stays empty. The heel of the meeting's bread stays on the river sill until the meeting ends. Ask why and you will not be told. Do not invent a rite to fill the cup.

Naenor wins the signing and loses the ship. Derdil's watch sets the Bound witness's chair with its back to the Tree at Leaf-Fall, and will not say why. A household that calls the colour a gift is a bad debtor in a city that employs the Bound to stand for honesty.

Lunbra shows you the expensive chair and does not ask you to sit until your house has been said. Vamar sets a coin on the open page, and the coin is not the fee. There is no hymn to appeal to. The office that could strike the row has no name in this book. Leave it unnamed.

Braetu sells a lamp for a name that will not come back, and keeps one berth dark with no one to bill. Mursur lights the lamp from the cook-fire, not from another lamp. A party that wants the far run is quoted here. A party that wants the isle is told it is a story.

Eolvaeth is a spring, a thin Tree, and camp-streets of people who came for a hinge and did not leave. You are fed. You are not written down. In a year the Tree does not speak, children leave a

wet leaf on the lip of the spring. Visitors from the core look for something to climb. There is nothing.

Sanbreo puts the beach-fee on the same slate as Vathne's sentence. The coin stays on the sill until the hull is gone. A neighbour who cannot barter a Tithe slides, next door to a gospel that is not this town's.

Harrow's Green is the neighbour's week as a present tense. Haelin speaks the fall. Borrowed children come up from the ford in the month the roads fill. The town is a few hundred hearths and a canopy, and it is not the march's capital. If you need a Heskoren Tree that works, this is the one. If you need the argument about why the next pot is not here, you are already late. That argument is at Natai, where Dumu leaves the gate-latch off while a complaint is said.

The hamlets are three kitchens and a ford. In clear weather the canopy is a dark on the far slope. In rain it is a rumour. Tora keeps the walk. A sibling goes and a sibling stays. Do not make them a town with a square. They do not have one.

The First Bowl is two settings of one bowl. The old green and the young guest-tree. The meal goes around before the colour, or Vilraet tries and the bowl is still out. A warden who will not sit is the fear. Vaelun, a day's walk away, still thinks the wood should have sat at their green.

Ndenjoo is the extra place, slightly back, and the lamps facing the table. A wreck walked uphill tonight is the opening. Soonke has already decided the stranger is alive. Njunda has not yet decided they are kin. If the hands stop, someone sat in the extra place or argued during the pour. Fixing it is manners. It is not a miracle.

How a town treats the same person

The Condition does not change when the person crosses a border. The welcome does. If you can feel that shift, you can run a journey without a new plot. The plot is the border.

A Long-Lived person in Threnmaieth is a courtier and an archivist the crown does not quite trust, because their memory is not the crown's ledger. In Maiethvael they are a patron of beds and books, useful and not filed. In Lestrand they are the banking house, a century of credit, and a marriage the market weighs coolly against the funerals. In the Waiting they are rare, and a rare memory is a treasure a thin pillar-system cannot afford to lose. On the Yield they are a guest

who will be asked to sit before they are asked to witness. In Rothallo they are a person with a Condition, shown to the far end of the table, however old the memory is. The Book does not make an exception for reverence.

A Two-Bodied person is the labor force almost everywhere, and the animal is a neighbour's name. On the Coast the bloodline is a trade dynasty. In the Waiting and on the dry east they are the ranging that keeps the herds. In Threnmaieth a heritable animal is a marriage the crown notices. Nowhere are they a nation. Do not give the wolf-folk a kingdom. Give them a family and a job.

A Returned person is respected where the work kills, and cold to the touch when the purpose is neglected. No town can furnish the purpose. A Book-hand may find a payable year. Nobody can supply a vengeance, a vow, or a person still to find. On the Coast that unreadableness is a bad contract. In the Waiting it is a soul the gospel does not know how to house. At an ancestor-meal the empty place is not their chair. If you blur those two doors, the Door-Keepers and the Returned will both correct you, and they will be right.

A Bound person is feared in the core, over-watched under the Tallied Crown, and employed on Naenor as the witness who still stood when the Grey Summer had killed the others. On the Ledger Coast they are the perfect notary, because the contract binds property and not persons, and the Coast likes a line it can price. In a thin land with no guild they are as likely to meet a rope as a table. The whisper is the same whisper everywhere. It suggests. It does not take the will. A town that punishes them for the whisper is punishing a fear, and the fear is older than the law.

An Unbound person is what a finished contract leaves. The core pities them and does not know how to buy the one thing they need, which is to be known. Family, an attic, or a paid sitting is what there is. The sector that furnishes green and halls cannot sell being known, and the Slide, the paid week after the official door has closed, will charge for the company and will not be family. If the party meets an Unbound person in a rich city, the ache is that the money is everywhere and useless for this.

A Far-Voiced person is revered where a voice is infrastructure, which is the core and the Coast, and dangerous everywhere if the feeling is not let out. A guild-trained Given voice and a Struck voice that came up from a drowning are the same Condition and should not be played as the

same person. In the Waiting the venting happens at worship, because there is no hall. At the hamlets there is no hall either, and a lapse is a family problem before it is a guild's. A Cry in a counted hall, a release-house, or a gift-hall is the same blow. Only the name of the room changes, and the name tells you whether the town will call it worship, a function, or an entry on a list.

One of the Stilled is wanted and licensed where there is a guild, and a travelling blessing where there is not. A resident stiller is ordinary in the rich infirmaries and a summer's luck at Harrow's, a decade's luck at Eolvaeth, a Near Mile luck at the Mill-hold. The Gaze that saves a patient is the Gaze the law watches. Most of what the hearings deal with is negligence. The rare charge is a person held still and left helpless. Do not let a town forget that the same look does both.

One of the Answered is a workshop in a city and a hazard if the workshop is taken away. Ember, Tide, Root, and Gale are not ancestry chapters. A Drakona is not an Ember nation, and a Tengu is not a Gale nation. The element is a Condition. The body was already a Kind. Idle is the danger. A lord who benches them, a yard that burned, a grief that takes the work away, and the element starts to speak in the room. The guilds exist to make the speaking happen at the forge, the hull, the stone, and the sail, not in the street.

One of the Taken-In is the backbone of a frontier and a rented lot in a stone city. Ornsael honours them because the land is thirsty. Orentel rents them by the season because the city wants grain and is not a forest. Threnmaieth furnishes their green and can withhold it. The Yield reads them as the land's own children. A polite core district eats what they grow and keeps them at arm's length. The bark and the antler are why. If the party is from a city, let them feel the flinch, and then let them eat the bread.

A Phoenix is not treated. A Phoenix is told. Towns that have never seen them already have an opinion, and the opinion is the weight. Revered, hunted, called a fraud, called a heresy, wanted for the ash. You do not need a stat block to have a town go quiet when the story arrives ahead of the person. One alive. The stories move when that life ends.

The Kept are the test of whether you understand a country. In the Waiting they are a verdict. In the Gift-Realm they are pitied in plenty. Under the Tallied Crown they are pitied and written down. In the Close they are the rank that sits nearest the host, and the school calls the hug rare so the rank can feel like a blessing. On the Coast they are simply people without an upkeep to

price, which is its own kind of invisibility. On the Yield a child who will not walk to a Motherfaith Tree may be Kept in a preacher's mouth and kin in the kitchen. At the hamlets a sibling walks and a sibling stays, and both are this year's fact. At Ndenjoo there is no colour to lack. The word Kept is a mainland word. Do not make the hall use it as a rank.

The same building, three names

Every land has the same institutions, because the Trees and the Conditions are everywhere the grafts reached. What a land calls the building shows what it thinks the building is for. Use the common tongue unless someone from that land is speaking. When they are speaking, use their word, and the table will hear the stance without a lecture.

A safety licence is a ticket in ordinary speech. Vaethorn asks for the blessing-to-practice. Lestrand shows the guild-ticket. Threnmaieth shows the crown-warrant. It is the same paper. It attaches to a hazardous use, the Gaze in public, a Cry in a crowd, an element let loose in a yard. It does not attach to being Conditioned. Most people hold no ticket. Two-Bodied, Long-Lived, Returned, the Taken-In, the Unbound, a Phoenix, and the Kept are neighbours, not licensees. A Bound person has no paper on the body. The contract is heard at a table.

A hall where a Far-Voiced person lets feeling out is a gift-hall in a devout land, a release-house on a merchant coast, and a counted hall under the Tallied Crown. Same room. The devout name says worship. The coast name says a function. The crown name says the room is on a list.

Proof that you belong is standing-for, someone who saw you Turn. Vaethorn calls it the speaking, and hears it as worship. Lestrand calls it warranting, and hears it as a commercial guarantee. Threnmaieth calls it the naming, and means you have been named to the crown. Only two crowns keep a census of persons. Trenledd's roll is one, and it is not holy. Threnmaieth's Threnhael is the other, and it calls itself care. Lestrand keeps a tax roll and will not keep a roll of people. Maiethvael keeps neither.

The maxim every child is taught is that the will is one's own. A Condition cannot seize another person's mind. There is no charge for that, because it does not happen. Harm done with a Condition splits in two. Letting your element vent, your Cry break, or your green go to seed is negligence, a nuisance, a guild matter. Turning a gift on someone on purpose is ordinary violent

crime. In practice the charge a hearing can say aloud is mostly the Stilled gaze: you held a citizen still. The rest is negligence. A Bound person can say, truthfully, that their contract cannot make you do anything. Whether the town believes them is where the polities diverge. Vaethorn reads the maxim as the Mother's own line, scripture. Lestrand reads it as the free-will clause, sound commercial law, and likes it because a contract that binds property and not persons makes a Bound person the perfect notary. Threnmaieth reads it as the crown's assurance, and uses that citation to justify the roll.

The watch, when it is called, holds a person until morning. It asks the same three questions. It does not investigate Conditions. Night-watch is often the Kept, whose nights are not spent on a Tithe, and the Two-Bodied, whose ranging is the Tithe, with a Far-Voiced person for the shout. A guild-hearing fines, suspends a ticket, binds a person back to apprenticeship. An open hearing is for willful harm. The charge is the act. "You are Stilled" is not a charge. "You gazed a person and left them helpless" is.

If you remember the names of the buildings, you can walk a stranger through a gate in any of the fifteen and have the gate sound like itself.

Rooms that are older than the argument

Three places are older than the count, and one climb refuses the count. You should be able to put a party in them without turning them into a plot about the Leaf-Mother.

The Low Wall stands in Orenbren lodging-country, outside Rothallo, a shoulder-high run of stone that does not enclose a town and does not face the grove. The Close will tell you it is theirs. The quarry is not the Close's quarry. The stone is from before the Walk. It is not a date for the Tree, and it is not Hildal's wall. That later wall is taller and still lived in. Three gaps. One might have held a post, one has been widened for a cart, one is only wide enough for a person, and the Close's labour-roster sometimes assigns a walk through that last gap as owed work. The Book cannot make the walk into ownership of the stone. Children climb the high dip. A panel mid-run once held letters that were taken off, not worn away. Watchers will fight any Cut-year a clerk tries to scratch into it. The Old Ways will leave a first meal at a gap and will not call the wall a guest-Tree. A warden wants the ribbons taken off, because children already treat it as a shrine and it is not one.

The Seeing-Ring is a hill of stones in Maiethorn's old Watching country, north-east of Maiethlir. Someone later put a shrine on the ring. Someone after that took the roof off and left the stones. Tithsael keeps the night, not as a service, but as a seeing. The lower ring makes you turn as you walk so that you look out. The upper work is a kinder quarry, steps that do not match, a socket that once held a door-beam, a warden's pecked mark over an older pattern. In the month of the Turning someone ties a cloth on the open socket. By the month contracts are reckoned, it is gone. Tithsael takes a colour-ribbon off and leaves a hug-ribbon. That is a Watcher's kindness the Seat will not understand. The origin did not drop the cloth. Someone on the hill tied it. Clockwise is the local habit of the walk, and a Watcher will not tell you why. Do not invent the why. A warden will tell you it is Turning-Week copied into stone, which is the overlay being confident. People come with a cough, a question, or a child who was neither hugged nor Given and wants a hill that does not owe them a name.

The Dry Stair, in Saelthael's dry east, climbs a rise above a well-town that is not Ornsael and not Larbril. The steps are worn in the middle. At the top a slab is cut like a threshold and has no wall, and a basin pecked in the rock has not held water in any summer a living person will swear to. The pecking is the wrong shape for a cistern and the right size for a pot, which is why a warden planted a slip there. The slip died. The Seat did not send a second. A thumb of dead wood sits in a crack. It will not green. People say the stair refused a mother. The rock was dry. Saelthael already knows about dirt. The refusal is the story they prefer. Children dare the last step. Visitors ask where the Tree is. The town points west, and then someone laughs. A few risers have a scratch that might be a person. The town rubs them with a thumb and does not read them aloud. A Threnmaieth clerk would want them copied. Do not let the clerk have them unless you want the hill to become a file.

These three are how you show a party that the world was already here. They are not the key to the Mother. They are stone, a night, and a dry basin. The arguments that arrive, a claim, a ribbon, a second slip in a pot, are enough scene for a session, and they leave the larger secret where it belongs, which is with you.

What you are afraid of, and the cure for it

The fear you named is that you do not know this world well enough to run it. The cure is not to memorize every street. It is to know which question a place asks, and what it thinks the neighbour asks instead.

When the party is on Maiethorn, ask yourself whose page they are about to be written on, or whose page they are refusing. The crown's, the hymn's, the Book's, the inn's slate, the wash's week, the pass levy, the hull's class. The Trees work. The pressure is proximity to the holy, and the pride of being the thick end.

When the party is on Strandoren, ask yourself what is being priced, signed, found, or watched for. The Trees also work. The faith is optional. The cruelty is a fade the city can see and will not catch, or a roll with no hymn, or a lamp sold as watch over a name that will not come back. The five powers are one shore arguing about paper. They are not five nations with five armies.

When the party is on Heskoren, ask yourself whether the Tree in front of them can do this week's work. If it can, you are at Harrow's, or at a young Hand like Natai's, or at Eolvaeth in a lucky year. If it cannot, someone is walking, or refusing to walk, or charging a beach while a gospel on the other coast calls the refusal empty. The wood is still arriving. Waiting is not a metaphor.

When the party is on Kumbaan, stop asking Tree questions. Ask whether they are alive, whether the extra place is set, and whether they can sleep through the day. Kin is a second night. It will not count at a mainland gate. That disappointment is the scene, if they try to spend it as papers.

When a person from one of these countries meets a person from another, let them be slightly wrong about each other, in the direction their country is wrong. The Tallied Crown thinks an unlisted cousin is failing a gift. The Gift-Realm thinks a list is faithlessness. The Coast thinks a hymn is a luxury. The Waiting thinks scarcity is a test of worth. The Yield thinks a pot without a meal is theft. The Close thinks a hug is a rank. All of them are living the same Trees and the same Tithe. None of them has the whole.

If you can say those six sentences in your own words, you know enough to begin. The world book will still be there when you need the share, the street, or the rule on a card.

An ordinary day, before anyone plots

Most of a session will not be a schism. It will be a household, a sickbed, and a street. If those feel thin, the philosophies will feel like labels. If those feel lived-in, the philosophies have somewhere to stand.

A marriage is ordinary. Two people, some of the household carrying a Condition and some not, children who will not stand at a Tree until they are ten. Because almost every family is mixed, nobody has a word for a mixed marriage as a problem. The problem, when it comes, is time and upkeep. A Two-Bodied parent's other self has a name the children know, and grows up in the house the way a person who is also an animal grows up in a house. A Far-Voiced household is a loud one, because the upkeep is feeling let out daily, and you do not get to sulk quietly through an evening. A Taken-In parent keeps the windows open and the rooms green. These are the accommodations. They are not tragedies.

The tragedy that does sit at a dinner table is the Long-Lived marriage. Aging stops on one side. It does not stop on the other. The Condition is not reliably inherited, so a Long-Lived person does not found a deathless dynasty. They outlive it. They bury a spouse. They bury children. Then they either stop, and live on alone, or begin again and outlive the next family too. Neither choice is cowardly. Both are paid at the table, over decades. If you only show Long-Lived people as archivists, you have missed the funeral.

Medicine is astonishing for a late-medieval world, and it is astonishing for one reason: the Conditions do the work a later century would do with industry. One of the Stilled holds a wound still under the knife, in a world with no anaesthetic worth the name. The same look is why they are licensed and quietly feared. The Returned do the plague wards and the recovery of bodies, because death has already taken them once and will not take them again until the purpose is done. A mortuary staffed by the dead is, inside this world, respected. To an outsider it is ghoulish. Both reactions are available to you. Use the outsider when the party is new. Use the respect when they have lived here. The rest of medicine is midwives, bonesetters, and herbalists, better staffed than our history because more people carry a useful becoming. The miracle is not evenly available. The great infirmaries cluster where the Trees and the money are. The frontier gets a travelling stiller or a prayer. And the deepest inequity is the one the Tithe already named:

you can be too poor to stay whole, and the medicine that treats a lapsing Condition is the medicine the poor can least reach.

A city is shaped by the fact that most of its adults have an upkeep. The Tree is at the centre, or the neighbour's Tree, or the wait for one. In a village the whole place watches one circle. In a city of tens of thousands, Turning-Week is still the festival, and the legal witness is the street, the quay-gang, or the courtyard that brought the child. The square is full. The memory is nested. Nobody pretends twenty thousand people saw one leaf.

Around that square the town builds the upkeep the way another town builds wells. Venting-halls for the Far-Voiced, often the same room as the performance. Potted groves and garden-commons so a Taken-In person who lives in stone does not go to seed indoors. Endowed libraries feeding a Long-Lived person's need for something new, often built by a Long-Lived house, because a house that does not die has centuries to endow and a Tithe that wants the novelty. Ranging-ground at the edge, where a Two-Bodied person can be the animal. These are as ordinary as a market cross where the polity treats them as public. On the Coast they are private, and the queue is the politics. Under the Tallied Crown they are public and withholdable, and the withholding is the politics. In the Waiting they are alms, and the thinness is the politics.

The dangerous trades sit at the edge for the same reason a tannery sits downwind. Stilled infirmaries and Answered workshops are set a little apart. Returned mortuaries sit near the dead. Not from disgust. From the logic of a bystander. Homes bend without a speech: a window that opens for a Taken-In guest, an evening built around a Far-Voiced vent, a threshold where a Long-Lived person waits to be asked across. A door held open is intimacy. A door refused is felt more than they will say.

Burial, a guest-meal, and what a house keeps are local, and you do not need a new religion to play them. The Old Ways set a place for the dead who stayed in the ground, and that place is not the Open Table's extra seat, and it is not a Returned person's chair. Travellers mix those three up. The people who keep them do not. When a party mixes them up, let the correction be ordinary and a little sharp. That correction teaches more than a lecture.

If a session is only a ferry, a bed, and a morning argument about a key, and the country is still recognizable, you are doing it right. The fifteen powers are there so the argument about the key has a history. They are not there so every scene has to name a polity.

The arguments you will hear at the table

You do not have to start a theological plot. These arguments are already in the way people ask for a bed.

The Motherfaith says the world received gifts and goes on receiving them, and the question is how to live worthy of a gift. There is no fall to be rescued from. "Tend what you are given" is as close as the faith comes to a commandment. The Kept, in the orthodox reading, were given wholeness. A minority reading says they were passed over, and that "wholeness" is a kindness the faithful tell them. Both readings are alive. The Struck are the sharper fight. One side says the Mother meets people at every door, the drowning and the oath and the death, and the Tree is only her ordinary hand. The other side says she gives only at the Tree, and a Struck person received their Condition by some other means, which is why they are a little suspect. You can run a whole campaign on which of those a town believes, without ever confirming which is true. Skeptics who bring their children and tend the upkeep are still of the faith. Belief in the Mother is honoured and not policed. That is why a skeptic warden can be a good warden.

The Watching keeps the Tree and refuses the mother-name. They are not a rustic survival on a frontier. They are a heartland practice, in Maiethorn's oldest districts, an older attention the Motherfaith grew over. They will sit beside a Speaking and describe. They will not confirm. If a Threnmaieth clerk wants the withheld line as a column, the Watcher will give the night or the description as dissent, and will not recant the withheld word as heresy. A Bare Tree Watcher will not say "she" to make a docket cleaner. Use them when a party wants a witness who will not take a side the town has already chosen.

The Fair Hand is what a dock does with a gift. It becomes a bargain. Leddvael made that civic. Other Strandoren towns wear it more lightly, as quay-charms and signing-watches. The Book-Hands are the people you meet. They are not villains for calling a colour a debt. They are a sincere ledger. The harm is when the ledger is asked to be the whole person, and a household that still says gift is filed as a risk. A Bound warden, or a Bound Book-hand, lives in both sentences at once. That person is a better scene than a debate.

The Old Ways are doors and first meals, older than the grafts on Heskoren. A healthy town Tree is a guest. A sickening Tree in an old grove starts the fight about who the host is, the warden or

the door-keeper, and both of them love the wood. They will not agree about the time before the Walk, a Before at the Tree against a Before with no Tree, and the ordinary room for that argument is a meal, not a battlefield. The First Bowl is that room. A meal refused, a night-watch held in an old green, a Road-hand arriving in the middle: that is how it starts, if you need it to start. Most years it is just the bowl going around before the colour.

The Open Table does not share these fights, because it does not have the Tree. Mainlanders keep trying to hand it one. A warden who crosses wants a tree to tend, a Book-hand wants a stamp, a Watcher wants a night watch. The hall has supper. "No one is a stranger twice" is said to a guest at the table. It is not a proverb for a quay, and it is not a pass. A Settler who sits a moon-feast twice has been called kin in a language with no book, and will discover, at the next mainland gate, that the language did not travel. That discovery is worth more than a speech about cultural difference.

Smaller rites stay local. Quay-charms, Kind-customs, a wet leaf on a spring, a pebble on a dry line, a heel left on a sill. People do them and will not say why. Your job is to keep the habit and refuse the explanation. The moment you explain the heel of the loaf, or the empty cup at Raitin, or the wet leaf at Eolvaeth, you have turned a life into a puzzle with an answer. The world book is full of these on purpose. Leave them unanswered. The players will feel the country more if the country has manners it will not translate.

What you know and the square does not

The square does not have this. Do not confirm it in play unless you mean to. The telling above still works if a table never hears it. You should have it, because otherwise the seams feel like mistakes.

The Leaf-Mother is real. She is kind, and she is finite. Each gift costs her something, and her reach has an edge. She cannot touch every child, and she cannot arrive at every crisis in time. The town Trees are her hands. When a Tree chooses, she is choosing. The Tithe is the weight of a real gift. It is not a trap.

The Kept are not all one thing. For most of them the hug is a kindness, a choice to leave them whole. Some were children she could not reach, held safe rather than gifted. She does not say

which is which, and neither can they. There is no later ceremony that sorts them. A child stands once. A missed week is not a second chance.

She gives at the Tree. She does not strike. A death, a drowning, or a pact sworn later is caught by lesser powers of her household, each of them limited to one kind of door, acting because she allows it. The Struck are still hers, because those hands are hers to send. They were reached for at the edge, which is why there is no ceremony and why they can feel half a step outside the town. One side of the faithful says she meets people at every door. The other says she gives only at the Tree. Each side is holding half of this.

Believers are right that she is real, kind, and that the gifts are gifts. Skeptics are wrong that nobody is there. They are right about the seam: Kept children who seem passed over, Struck people who arrive with no rite, a giving that thins where the Trees are thin. They have called a limit an absence. What she is, beyond a kind and finite giver, what she wants besides the gifts, where she can be met, and why the reach ends where it ends, are still unwritten. The history shows the edge moving outward as the cuttings spread. It does not name a cause. Do not add one.

There is one Phoenix alive. When that life ends, a white-fire leaf falls for one child, somewhere, and the stories move. Playing one is a decision the whole table makes. The world already has an opinion.

The Pourers are a circle of Long-Lived people. A member is asked once. Most say no, and a refusal is not punished. Members give memory into a cup, one year at a time, of their own accord, and may stop. The papers of that year go on a shelf. That work is real. An inner circle also takes, from a person they have chosen, the memories and the hard-won understanding that define a life, and gives what was taken to a Long-Lived founder. The person can still speak, still recognize the world, and still recognize the loss. The founder believes the store can make them a god, and has accepted that the attempt might ruin what they hope to save. The notes record the belief. They do not say the crossing can happen. Do not call the founder a god in anything a player reads.

The presence in the cup, the Unspent, is older than the circle that named it. It stores what it is given. It does not make plans, it does not give a Condition, and it does not save anyone from

death. The Pourers say they made it. They did not. It lets them say so. The taking is the inner circle's, not the cup's idea.

The Walled Book, the Pourers, and the Protectors are three separate groups. The Protectors, in public, are a rumour about people who catch a Phoenix fire. How they do it stays in the GM chapter of the world book. Do not braid it into the Leaf-Mother, and do not braid it into the cup.

If you only keep three sentences from this last part, keep these. She is real, kind, and she cannot reach everyone. The hug does not sort itself. The inner circle takes, and the cup did not ask them to.